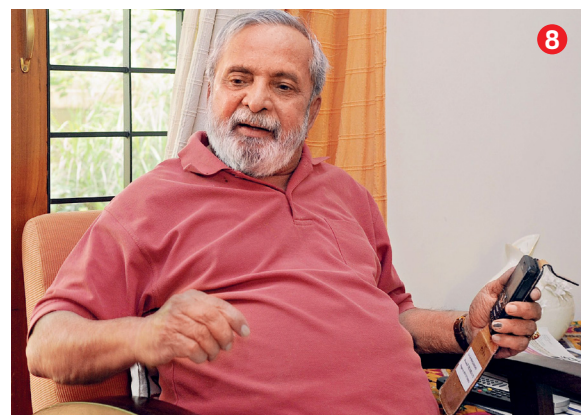


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7. Dilip Purushottam Chitre *(Marathi)*

8. U.R. Ananthamurthy *(Kannada)*

sorts in the literary scene in Gujarati. Khakhar was known primarily as a painter of international fame, and though he wrote an intriguing play, *Maujila Manilal*, and several short and long stories, writers of his time hardly ever thought of him as a 'writer'. The literary establishment was inimical to Suresh Joshi because he was greatly different, had imbibed many literary traditions and was brutally intolerant of mediocrity. Joshi lived passionately in the company of words and ideas with a profound human commitment. He taught, lectured, wrote, edited and published incessantly for over three decades to keep alive the lifeline of a culture he saw being dehumanised day by day. *Vani*, *Manisha*, *Kshitij*, *Uhapoh*, *Etad*, *Sayujya* and *Setu*—the journals he edited, established and abandoned, have become synonymous with his name. His own oeuvre, especially prose, both critical and creative, changed the tenor of Gujarati diction. *Gruhpravesh*, his first collection, transformed the linear short story into a web-like structure of organic complexity. Khakhar had to face scorn and violence for being a homosexual. Joshi had to face isolation due to his sharp criticism of his contemporaries. Yet Joshi's works, like *Janantike*, *Gruhpravesh* and *Chhinnapatra*, were recognised by Gujarati readers as being in a class by themselves immediately on their publication. Khakhar expressed his disdain for the world by using an uncanny sense of humour. Turning a piece of 'foreign soap' into a device to comment on the frailties and passions of ordinary folk, he could span the profoundly philosophical with the utmost mundane with an ease that Gujarati literature has not known before or since. Bhupen spent most of his energy in painting a landscape peopled by observant and ugly faces and bodies. Together, they posited a new idea of beauty in Gujarati letters. The Gujarat of today would hardly have tolerated their presence.

I have spent close to three decades of my life in Maharashtra and over three decades in Gujarat. It is natural for me to speak of the Marathi and Gujarati writers of my choice. However, one more language that has deeply impacted my literary taste is Kannada. It has had a major place in my life and mind through a series of personal circumstances. Of Kannada writers, the ones who made deep impact on me have been Girish Karnad, Shantinath Desai and U.R. Ananthamurthy. The ones I shall recommend to those who would like to read Kannada literature are Tejaswi Purnachandra and Vivek Shanbag. The ones I adore the most are Shivarama Karanth and Devanoor Mahadeva. I had read Ananthamurthy's *Sanskara* soon after it appeared in the English translation by A.K. Ramanujan. I used to meet Ananthamurthy when I was a young lecturer and he a professor at Mysore University. Later, he moved to Kerala and I moved to Gujarat to teach at Baroda. However, when he headed the National Book Trust and, later, the Sahitya Akademi, we met frequently. He supported my idea of giving up my university job and moving into an Adivasi village. But these were personal matters. I was aware of his literary standing, had read all his works and got some of them translated into Gujarati. What made me respect him more than I did other writers was his courage to openly espouse social causes. During his last year, he wrote a somewhat rushed, though passion-